



AP PHOTO

The 39-year-old Congress scion does not pretend to have all the answers. He is, however, raising some very relevant questions by completely upturning the old traditional way of playing politics. Single-handedly, he made youth the buzzword during the recent general elections. So much so that even an octogenarian like L.K. Advani rushed to the neighbourhood gym to pick up a pair of dumbbells. Rahul didn't need to resort to such gimmicks. His campaign was a canvas of vibrant energy as he dashed about the countryside, reaching out to far-flung tribals and downtrodden Dalits. In contrast, the BJP bandwagon looked just a little jaded. And the results that poured in proved that it was the young heir who had caught the voters' imagination. The Congress gladly credited Rahul with the surprising Lok Sabha win. And any other win that followed. He may look like the dimpled darling of the chatterati, but he has also emerged as the Gandhi of the new millennium. To him goes the credit of doing things his way, regardless of the ridicule, and finally having that acknowledged as the Chosen Way. It's the power of a win. "His politics has not changed. Only those who criticised his politics for the last six years are today embracing his strategies," says Milind Deora, a fellow Lok Sabha backbencher.

Undoing the Politics of SYCOPHANCY

The traditional sycophantic Congressmen still have not completely figured out their new leader. Their accolades are brushed aside with an impatient nod; their elaborate plans to hold an All India Congress Committee (AICC) session to felicitate him were met with a strange lack of enthusiasm, forcing them to junk the idea. Rahul's non-appearance, when they assembled outside his house on his 39th birthday with a 39-kg cake baffled party workers, who ended up feeding it to his poster. Whoever changed the script forgot to re-programme them. They have never met the likes of him—a Congress leader who sends hangers-on in the Delhi durbar scurrying back to their constituencies, who dashes off in the middle of the night to dine with a Dalit family and who has more patience for the cheeky questions of schoolchildren than the platitudes and panygerics of his own colleagues.

"Just because I am the outcome of a system doesn't mean I can't change it. It gives me the position to do certain things," he says, further confounding the already confused Congress. Yet, Rahul is aware of the irony of his situation. That he, a young scion, is trying to introduce the concept of democracy to a 125-year-old party that is brought up on a strict diet of dynasty. Regardless, ever since he took over as general secretary two years ago, he has begun the process of elections within the youth wings even though the first one in Punjab, elected another young dynast as its youth chief, Ravneet Singh Bittu, grandson of former chief minister Beant Singh, Rahul seems confident that once the process is underway, it will reach out far beyond the existing Congress fiefdoms.

WHETHER IT IS REACHING OUT TO THE YOUTH OR RURAL POOR, RAHUL IS A MAN WITH A MISSION